

Making the Internet Less Addictive: A Toolset for Improving Personal Productivity Through Controlled Content Exposure

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I. Introduction

Overview of the Problem

The internet is a major part of daily life, but many popular platforms are designed to keep users engaged for as long as possible. Features like algorithmic recommendations, infinite scrolling, and autoplay make it easy to keep consuming content without realizing how much time has passed. While useful for entertainment and discovery, these features can lead to excessive and unplanned internet use.

Why This Problem Matters

In the Philippines, people spend an average of over 3 hours per day on social media, showing how much time online activities consume. Even small reductions in daily usage can result in meaningful time savings. Studies also suggest that excessive short-form content consumption is linked to reduced attention span, self-control, and academic performance, making this issue relevant to productivity and personal development.

Who Is Affected

This problem mainly affects students and working individuals who rely on the internet for both productivity and leisure. Frequent distractions can affect studying, work tasks, and long-term focus. Those who want better time management and more intentional internet use are the primary beneficiaries of solutions addressing this issue.

II. Problem Description

Nature of the Problem

Modern digital platforms are designed to keep users engaged for as long as possible. Features such as algorithmic recommendations, short-form video feeds, and autoplay encourage passive consumption, making it hard to notice how much time is spent online. Unlike intentional internet use, such as searching for specific information, this passive consumption often extends beyond a user's original purpose. Over time, this behavior contributes to poor time awareness and reduced control over how online time is spent.

Supporting Data

In the Philippines, people spend an average of over three hours per day on social media, showing that a significant portion of daily time is dedicated to online platforms (Howe, 2025). Research also links excessive short-form video consumption to decreased academic performance and reduced attention span (Haliti-Sylaja & Sadikub, 2024). In addition, individuals who frequently consume short videos may experience challenges with executive control and self-regulation, further limiting their productivity and ability to manage time effectively (Yan et al., 2024).

These findings highlight that prolonged exposure to highly engaging, rapidly changing content can negatively affect focus, attention, and overall time management.

Limitations and Challenges

Not all internet use is harmful, and not all users experience negative effects from prolonged engagement. The impact of digital distraction depends on individual habits, goals, and self-control.

Existing productivity solutions often rely on self-discipline, such as manually blocking apps or setting strict time limits. Users may ignore or override these measures, making it difficult to maintain consistent behavior. This shows the need for tools that support intentional internet use without fully restricting access or reducing the utility of digital platforms.

III. Proposed Solution

Overview

The proposed solution is a digital productivity toolset designed to reduce distraction and support intentional internet use. The core idea is to modify popular platforms to minimize addicting features, helping users stay focused without fully restricting access.

A proof-of-concept feature has already been tested. *I am breaking the fourth wall to tell you that yes, this feature is in fact real and currently active:* a Firefox Tampermonkey userscript that detects a specified time of day and deletes all YouTube recommendations, notifications, and hides video comments and subscriptions, leaving only the search bar and a link to user-created playlists. In addition, upon detecting a YouTube Shorts page, it redirects the URL to load the video as a full-length version. This prevents endless passive consumption and encourages active, purposeful browsing.

The full solution expands on this approach to include multiple sites, apps, and devices, with customizable features, integration with built-in screen-time tools, and a comprehensive support system for personal productivity.

Feature List

The toolset could include the following features:

- **Intentional Access Design:** Preserves essential platform functionality such as search bars, direct links, and user-created playlists, encouraging purposeful use rather than complete restriction.
- **Algorithmic Feed Suppression:** Automatically hides algorithmic recommendations on YouTube and similar platforms at specified times to reduce compulsive consumption.
- **Passive Scrolling Suppression:** The system detects infinite scroll mechanisms such as short-form and feed-based content and prevents passive scrolling by disabling and preventing new posts from loading without explicit user action.
- **Screen-Time Integration:** Enables users to define specific time windows (e.g., study hours or work hours) during which distraction-minimizing features are automatically applied, and notifies users when they exceed pre-set daily or hourly screen time limits.
- **Behavioral Nudges and Feedback:** Provides subtle reminders or usage summaries that inform users when they transition from intentional browsing to prolonged passive consumption.

Target Users

- Students who struggle to stay focused while studying due to frequent social media and video platform distractions.
- Working individuals who rely on the internet for tasks but are easily pulled into attention-grabbing content.
- Heavy social media users who want better control over their screen time without completely quitting platforms.
- Productivity-focused users who prefer tools that encourage better habits instead of strict blocking.

Expected Impact

- Reduced compulsive internet use by removing endless, attention-grabbing content loops.
- Improved focus and time awareness through intentional, choice-based browsing.
- Better productivity for studying, working, and goal-oriented tasks.
- Healthier digital habits without fully restricting access to useful platforms.

IV. Conclusion

Summary

Modern internet platforms are designed to capture attention and encourage continuous engagement, often leading to unplanned and excessive use. This project addresses that problem by proposing a productivity-focused toolset that removes attention-grabbing features while preserving useful platform functions. By suppressing algorithm-driven feeds, limiting compulsive interaction, and encouraging intentional content selection, the solution helps users regain control over their time and focus. Rather than relying on strict blocking or self-discipline alone, the tool supports healthier digital habits through design, making more mindful internet use both practical and sustainable.

Considerations

The references used in this report include a mix of primary and tertiary sources. In addition, while some findings show a relationship between social media use and reduced attention or academic performance, most do not establish direct causality. These limitations suggest that the problem should be interpreted as a strong association rather than a proven cause-and-effect relationship. Moreover, Haliti-Sylaja and Sadikub (2024) collected data using convenience sampling, which is common in educational research but may limit broader applicability.

Despite these limitations, the proposed tool may still be effective in reducing unintentional internet use by altering platform functionality rather than relying solely on user self-control.

V. References

Yan, T., Su, C., Xue, W., Hu, Y., & Zhou, H. (2024). Mobile phone short video use negatively impacts attention functions: an EEG study. *Frontiers in human neuroscience*, 18, 1383913. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2024.1383913>

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